

THE SHARMA-WILLIAMS FAMILY STORIES

Three generations of love, laughter, and legacy

3 Generations

10 Memories Preserved

1950s - Present

From Delhi to Denver

Created with Heirloom
Family Memory Preservation

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Our Family Tree

First Generation

- Kamala Devi Sharma
Matriarch | Born 1942 in Jaipur, India
- Rajan Sharma
Patriarch | Born 1938 in Delhi, India

Second Generation

- Priya Sharma-Williams
Daughter & Mother | Born 1968 in Delhi, India
- James Williams
Father | Born 1965 in Denver, Colorado

Third Generation

- Maya Williams
Granddaughter | Born 1998 in San Francisco, CA
- Arjun Williams
Grandson | Born 2002 in San Francisco, CA

Childhood Memories

Kamala Devi Sharma • 1950s

My Mother's Kitchen Magic

"Every Sunday morning, my mother would wake up before sunrise to make fresh jalebis. The smell of saffron and sugar syrup would fill our small house in Jaipur. She never measured anything—just knew by feeling. 'The oil must sing to you,' she'd say. I watched her hands dance over the kadhai for years before she let me try. The first time I made them alone, after she passed, I cried into the batter. But they tasted just like hers."

Emotion: nostalgia | Place: Family home, Jaipur

Key moment: "The oil must sing to you"

Youth & Coming of Age

Kamala Devi Sharma • 1964

The Day I Became a Teacher

"I was twenty-two when I walked into my first classroom in Jaipur. Thirty-five pairs of eyes looking at me, expecting wisdom. I was terrified! My hands were shaking as I wrote my name on the blackboard. Then a little girl in the front row smiled at me—her two front teeth were missing. That smile gave me courage. I taught for forty years after that day, and I never forgot that little girl's gift."

Emotion: pride | Place: Government School, Jaipur

Key moment: "That smile gave me courage"

Rajan Sharma • 1960

The Night I Met Kamala

"It was at a wedding in Delhi, 1960. I was supposed to be watching the ceremony, but I kept looking at this young woman across the room. She caught me staring and didn't look away. My friend nudged me: 'That's the schoolteacher everyone's talking about. Very educated. Too smart for you!' I walked up to her anyway. The first thing she said was, 'You're blocking my view of the bride.' I said, 'Then I'll be your view instead.' She laughed, and I was lost forever."

Emotion: love | Place: Delhi wedding hall

Key moment: "She laughed, and I was lost forever"

Priya Sharma-Williams • 1992

When London Rain Brought Me Love

"I was doing my medical residency in London, 1992. It was pouring rain, and I'd forgotten my umbrella—again. I ducked into a jazz club to escape the downpour. A man was playing saxophone on stage, eyes closed, lost in the music. When he opened his eyes, he looked right at me standing there, dripping wet, and smiled without missing a note. After the show, he came over and said, 'You look like you need some sunshine.' I said, 'You sound like sunshine.' James still plays that song he was playing when we met. He calls it 'Rain in Delhi.'"

Emotion: love | Place: Jazz club, London

Key moment: "You look like you need some sunshine"

Priya Sharma-Williams • 1995

Bringing Two Worlds Together

"Our wedding was chaos—beautiful chaos. We had both Hindu and Christian ceremonies, in Delhi and Denver. My mother spent weeks teaching James's mother how to drape a saree. His father learned to say 'Namaste' with perfect pronunciation. When the pandit and the pastor both blessed us, standing side by side, I knew our children would be lucky. They'd have twice the love, twice the traditions, twice the stories to tell."

Emotion: joy | Place: Delhi and Denver

Key moment: "They'd have twice the love, twice the traditions"

Maya Williams • 2013

The Summer I Found My Story

"When I was fifteen, I spent a summer in Jaipur with Nani. One afternoon, she pulled out a tin box full of old photographs I'd never seen. There was Nana as a young man, standing proudly by a bridge. Mom as a little girl, eating ice cream with sticky hands. And a black and white photo of people I didn't recognize. 'Who are they, Nani?' She went quiet. 'People we lost during Partition. This is why we tell stories, beta. So they are never truly gone.' That summer, I decided to become a filmmaker. To make sure no story is ever lost."

Emotion: nostalgia | Place: Nani's house, Jaipur

Key moment: "This is why we tell stories, beta. So they are never truly gone."

Maya Williams • 2024

Why I Created Heirloom

"Last year, Nana had a stroke. For three days, he couldn't speak. I sat by his bed, terrified that all his stories—the bridges, old Delhi, how he met Nani—would disappear with him. When he recovered, the first thing he said was, 'Did I ever tell you about the river at Haridwar?' I started recording that same day. Every story, every voice, every detail. That's when I knew I had to build something for all families, not just ours. So that no one has to fear losing the voices they love."

Emotion: love | Place: Hospital, San Francisco

Key moment: "So that no one has to fear losing the voices they love"

Learning Hindi from Nani's Stories

"I never took Hindi classes growing up. But somehow I understand it, because of Nani. Every video call, she mixes Hindi and English, and I just... know. She'd tell me stories and I'd ask, 'Nani, what does that word mean?' She'd explain, then test me the next week. Now when I visit India, people are surprised—'Your Hindi is so good!' I tell them, 'I learned it from love stories and cooking instructions.'"

Emotion: joy | Place: Video call from college

Key moment: "I learned it from love stories and cooking instructions"

Adulthood & Family Life

Rajan Sharma • 1975

Building the Bridge at Haridwar

"In 1975, I was assigned to build a bridge over the Ganges at Haridwar. Engineers said the current was too strong, the river too sacred to tame. But I spent weeks watching the water, learning its moods. One morning, an old priest told me, 'Don't fight the river, son. Dance with it.' That bridge still stands today. I take my grandchildren there and tell them: respect what you cannot control, and you'll find a way."

Emotion: pride | Place: Haridwar, Ganges River

Key moment: "Don't fight the river, son. Dance with it."

James Williams • 2010

My Father's Last Song

"Dad taught me saxophone when I was eight. He was a session musician—never famous, but he played with legends. The night before he passed, he couldn't speak anymore, but he held my hand and hummed the melody of 'My Favorite Things.' I sat with him until morning, humming along. Now I play it at the end of every concert. No one knows why. It's just for him and me."

Emotion: sadness | Place: Hospital room, Denver

Key moment: "He held my hand and hummed"

Every life has a story worth preserving.

This book was created with Heirloom

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